LINNAEUS'S TWO-TOED SLOTH

Choloepus didactylus

PART A — WHO IS THIS ANIMAL?

WHERE DOES IT LIVE?

South America — tropical rainforest canopy

IS IT SAFE OR IN DANGER?

Least concern

PART B — HOW THIS LIVING SYSTEM WORKS

1. WHAT CAN IT SEE, HEAR, OR FEEL?

- Its hearing is keen and may help it sense movement in the canopy.
- Its eyesight is weak but can detect shapes and light changes.
- Its nose detects food and other sloths through smell.
- Its curved claws feel the tension and texture of each branch it grips.

Observation Prompt: What do you see it paying attention to right now?

2. WHERE DOES IT LIVE — AND WHY?

- It spends almost its entire life hanging upside down in the rainforest canopy.
- Dense tree cover provides both food and camouflage from eagles and ocelots.
- It descends to the ground only once a week to defecate.
- Green algae that grows in its fur helps it blend into leafy branches.

Observation Prompt: What would happen if this habitat changed?

3. HOW DOES IT SEND MESSAGES?

- It is mostly silent but hisses and moans when threatened.
- It slashes with its long claws as a defense when grabbed.
- Stillness itself is a signal — staying motionless is how it avoids detection.
- A curled body position in the branches signals that it is resting safely.

Observation Prompt: Can you spot a behavior that might be a signal?

4. WHAT DOES IT DO WHEN SOMETHING CHANGES?

- When disturbed, it moves slowly to a denser cluster of branches.
- It will bite and claw if it cannot escape a predator.
- Louder sounds cause it to slow its movements further or stay completely still.
- It changes trees when its food source in one tree is used up.

Observation Prompt: What happened when someone walked by?

5. HOW DOES IT LEARN?

- A young sloth clings to its mother for up to a year after birth.
- It learns which trees and leaves to eat by riding with its mother.
- Young sloths gradually explore nearby branches while staying within the mother's range.

Observation Prompt: Does this behavior look practiced?

6. HOW DOES IT HAVE BABIES?

- A female gives birth to a single young after about ten months of gestation.
- The infant clings to the mother's belly and is carried everywhere she goes.
- The mother gives birth while hanging upside down in the canopy.
- Young sloths cling tightly and learn the canopy slowly over many months.

Observation Prompt: What might babies need to survive?

7. WHAT ARE ITS LIMITS?

- Its very low metabolic rate means it produces little body heat.
- On the ground it is nearly helpless against predators.
- Loss of rainforest trees removes both its food and its hiding places.
- Very loud disturbances can disrupt its activity and foraging patterns.

Observation Prompt: What could make this animal leave or stop moving?

8. WHAT DOES THIS TEACH US ABOUT LIFE?

- Being slow and still is a survival strategy, not a weakness.
- Its fur, posture, and algae growth all work together to hide it from predators.
- A sloth's survival depends on a whole forest — not just one branch.

Final Question: Is what you see the whole story — or just part of it?

What a living thing can sense becomes its reality.
Every system lives inside its environment.